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The Editors
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Dear Editor,

I am pleased to submit my manuscript, “**Neighbourhood Structures and Ranking Operators for the Interval Job Shop Scheduling Problem**,” for consideration as a regular research article in *Computers & Operations Research*. The paper addresses the Interval JSP, where processing times are bounded but uncertain, and contributes on both theoretical and computational fronts.

On the theoretical side, I formalise the notion of *extreme critical paths* — arcs critical in either the best- or worst-case scenario graph — and define a neighbourhood $H(\sigma)$ on this basis. I prove that $H(\sigma)$ satisfies feasibility, connectivity and the no-loss-of-improving-neighbours property under any admissible interval ranking operator. Five neighbourhood variants (N_1 , N_2 , N_3 , N_{ext} and a new variant N_8) are formulated within this framework; the adaptations of the Nowicki–Smutnicki extended neighbourhood and of recent crisp-JSP reinsertion moves to the interval setting are, to the best of my knowledge, novel. On the empirical side, the paper reports a 12,300-run study on 82 benchmark instances of up to 1000 operations, organised in three phases: a 5×4 comparison of four interval ranking operators (EV, LEX1, LEX2, YX), a head-to-head comparison of the five neighbourhoods after per-neighbourhood irace tuning of a tabu search metaheuristic, and a comparison against three published IJSP solvers. The irace-tuned tabu search with N_2 reduces mean relative error by $\approx 57\%$ over the previous best published IJSP solver on every one of the 82 instances.

I believe the paper aligns well with the scope of *Computers & Operations Research*: it combines a constructive theoretical framework with an extensive numerical study and explicit comparisons against the prior state of the art. In line with the journal’s emphasis on reproducibility, all raw run logs, aggregated CSVs, irace tuning records, instance files and analysis scripts are openly available on Zenodo ([10.5281/zenodo.2056288](https://zenodo.org/record/2056288)), with per-instance results on the 70 Taillard instances in a separate supplementary document ([10.5281/zenodo.2056285](https://zenodo.org/record/2056285)). I confirm that this manuscript has not been published previously, is not under consideration by any other journal, and that all listed contributors have approved the submission. I declare no competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported. Thank you for considering this submission.

Sincerely,

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